

Post-incident review PIR-2025-028

Order Management: intermittent timeouts

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 10 January 2025, Order Management experienced intermittent timeouts in production (AU East) for about 160 minutes. Users posted about the problem on social media, and the support team escalated it. Investigation found that the autoscaler reached its maximum instance count during a traffic peak.

Impact

Users of Order Management saw intermittent timeouts for about 160 minutes. The service owner, Commerce Platform, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:03 First signal received.
- 09:22 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:53 Likely cause identified.
- 10:10 Mitigation applied.
- 10:32 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that the autoscaler reached its maximum instance count during a traffic peak.

It took time to work out which team owned the affected component.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Assign a named owner for the component in the service catalogue.
- Add a circuit breaker and timeout on the upstream call.
- Exercise the rollback path in staging as part of every release.